

Defensive Structure & Pressing Analysis of Real Madrid

Introduction

The following analysis is based on a video compilation containing 22 clips from nine different matches.

The contextual background of these matches was not fully available, which made the interpretation more complex. A significant part of the material appears to come from the pre-season preparation period, while some clips may originate from official competitive matches.

Across the clips, different player selections and tactical variations were observed, both in structural organization and pressing behaviour. Therefore, some of the defensive patterns identified may be influenced by experimentation, rotation, or specific match contexts.

General Defensive Structure

Real Madrid's primary defensive organization is based on a **4-3-3 structure** in a high block.

The structure consists of:

- 4 defenders
- 3 central midfielders
- 3 attacking players (1 striker + 2 wingers)

They apply an aggressive high press, positioning the attacking line close to the opponent's build-up phase. The main objective is to force play toward the flank, where they attempt to isolate and close the ball carrier, creating a pressing trap near the touchline.

Pressing actions are frequently initiated against the opponent's centre-backs, with two main variants observed:

Variant A – Striker + Winger Press

- The striker presses one centre-back
- The winger jumps onto the second centre-back
- The fullback steps forward to support

Consequence:

The wide channel behind the winger can become exposed.

Variant B – Striker + Central Midfielder Press

- The striker presses the ball-side centre-back
- A central midfielder jumps to press the second centre-back
- The winger holds a slightly deeper position

Consequence:

Space can open in central midfield, often creating temporary numerical superiority (e.g., 3v2) for the opponent.

Situational Adjustment – Mid Block

Depending on the match context (game state, scoreline, or late phases of the game), Real Madrid may drop into a more controlled **4-1-4-1 mid-block structure**.

In this scenario:

- The defensive midfielder stays deeper
- The midfield line becomes more compact horizontally
- The pressing intensity decreases
- The team prioritizes compactness and space control rather than aggressive ball recovery

Recurrent Structural Situations

Due to the aggressive nature of the high press:

- Wide channels may open when wide players jump forward

- Central gaps may appear when midfielders leave their zone
- The defensive line can remain exposed in equal numerical situations

Strategic Plan to Break the High Press

Strategic Principle – Mixed Build-Up

Based on the observed defensive structure, the proposed strategy is to apply a **mixed build-up approach**.

The key principle is that the player in possession must make the first correct tactical decision based on the opponent's pressing reaction.

The build-up should not be predetermined. Instead, it must be adaptive and based on:

- Who initiates the press
- From which line the pressure comes
- Where numerical superiority appears

Option 1 – Exploit the Flank (If Winger Jumps)

Option 2 – Progress Through the Centre (If Midfielder Jumps)

If a central midfielder steps forward to press:

- Central midfield coverage becomes reduced
- A temporary 3v2 or 3v3 advantage may appear centrally

In this case, progression through the centre becomes possible through:

- Short combinations
- Third-man movements
- Vertical passes between lines

Option 3 – Attract and Isolate (Play Into 3v3 Last Line)

Another solution is to deliberately attract the opponent's first and second pressing lines closer to our build-up.

This can be done through:

- Short circulation
- Controlled possession
- Drawing midfielders and wingers forward

Once the pressing block shifts higher:

- The defensive line may remain isolated
- A 3v3 situation can be created in the last line

At that moment, a direct vertical pass can be played toward the attacking line.

The objective is to exploit:

- Speed advantage
- Physical superiority
- 1v1 quality
- Aerial strength

The attacking reference should be selected based on the specific strengths of our players.

Training Task Design (Simulation Approach)

Training Philosophy

In my opinion, the most effective way to prepare the team is through **realistic game simulation**.

Specific training time should be allocated to reproduce the opponent's pressing structure and behaviours as accurately as possible.

The training process should follow two stages:

1. **Without opposition** – to fix positioning, movements, and decision patterns.
2. **With opposition** – to simulate real pressure and decision-making under stress.

Simulation Structure

One team reproduces Real Madrid's pressing behaviour:

- 4-3-3 high press
- Different pressing variants (winger jump / midfielder jump)
- Flank-oriented pressing traps

The second team represents our team and works on:

- Recognizing who initiates the press
- Identifying where space appears
- Detecting numerical or qualitative superiority
- Making the correct first decision in build-up